

Interview **[Leroy]** Transcript

September 10, 2024, 7:02PM

<Interviewer 1 started transcription>

Interviewer 1 0:06 Well, thank you for joining us, **[Leroy]**, and for agreeing to participate in this study. Do you agree to having the interview be recorded and transcribed?

[Leroy] 0:19 Yes.

Interviewer 1 0:21 OK, we're going to begin the interview by asking what have been your emotional and spiritual challenges in Christian ministry?

[Leroy] 0:33 OK. Uh, one of the main challenges in ministry is wanting more for someone than they want for themselves, and the struggle is seeing the potential in other people when they don't seem to see the same potential in themselves or they do harmful behaviors. And it just kind of breaks the heart of a minister to wanna see other people flourish when it doesn't appear they want to flourish themselves. Another piece is just seeing the another challenge I guess is just seeing the uh brokenness and hurt of families and people who. Through one situation or another just cannot seem to. Find peace or breakthrough. Or maybe there's family crisis or health issues. Uh & Ministers just carry those things with their congregation. That's just part of the nature of the job of shepherding. Well, is is carrying in an empathetic way with with people through their struggles. So it's probably very similar to counseling. Sometimes.

Interviewer 1 2:03 So the idea of wanting more for someone, it sounds as if in in that situation that you can see a way forward... that if they would only make some change or another that their life could be better in some sense, and that they're not working hard towards that or they're not integrating the things that that you could see would be really helpful for them. Is that what you're saying?

[Leroy] 2:35 Yeah, I think I think that's true. I mean, you know, as a minister, you try to be healthy spiritually, mentally, emotionally, physically, socially. I mean, you try to embody. A healthy individual and and then you're trying to share the good news of E Jesus, the gospel, the message of having a relationship with Christ and relationship with the community. And so when you see people fall into behaviors and habits and mindsets that that don't. You know that

don't connect with that and you you just want more for them than you feel like they're wanting for themselves and you see it for them.

Interviewer 1 3:25 Umm.

[Leroy] 3:25 And it's just sad that to not, you know, you can't make someone do something or be someone or change, they have to intrinsically want it so. Yeah, that's that's a challenge. That's one of the big challenges, I guess.

Interviewer 1 3:47 Is that a challenge personally? How is that personally or emotionally challenging for you when you're in that situation with someone? Or is it not challenging?

[Leroy] 3:59 Yeah. No, I, uh, I think obviously all kinds of people and personalities do ministry. In different ways, I know some people that it is very in internal for them and they take it and they carry it and they can't sleep at night and all those things. For me personally, I I think I do a pretty good job of separating those things. So I think I can listen well and reflect with people and care well, but then I have a I think I can go ahead and separate those and allow myself to become healthy as an individual. So I don't tend to carry those very far, but I will bring them to my prayer list. And I'm I'm pretty engaged in my prayer life and will pray for them regularly. But then I kind of released that to the Lord like I do other things in my personal life. So yeah.

Interviewer 1 5:00 Something that we've wondered about is how it is to move from one thing to another. For example, doing a wedding one day and a funeral the next day. Or working with someone with one kind of problem or issue and then going and having to preach a sermon right after. Is this is part of the emotional and spiritual challenges for you of being in in ministry?

[Leroy] 5:30 Sure. Sure. Yeah, you get bad news right before you walk up, and you're supposed to share a message. That's good news or, you know, the back and forth. I think that you know this is just for me personally. Uh, I I enjoy the challenge & ups and downs in the backs and forths. I mean, for me, I I guess I I can I can segment segment things fairly well I suppose for others that it is very challenging and they'll carry the emotions along. But you know, they calesia astes there's a time for everything. There's a time for joy and a time for pain and time, for sorrow

and a time for celebration. And. So I guess personally for me, just to me, you're interviewing me. That's that's I don't have a lot of trouble segmenting those times.

Interviewer 1 6:33 Yeah. So in some way, that skill is really something that has helped you or does help you because you said that you see it as a challenge, or you enjoy the challenge of redirecting or moving from this to that. It seems you can do that well...being with one person and then shifting gears to go be present with other people. That seems to be a skill of yours.

[Leroy] 7:01 I think so. I mean, obviously one of the components is not taking your work home with you. I mean, you as counselors probably are having to practice that all the time. So you know, when I'm carrying something with someone in a congregation or another pastor that I'm working with, I need to make sure I also walk into my home with my family and my wife and my kids and and compartmentalize as well. And certainly, you know, there are times to debrief things with my wife or, you know, whatever. But I I do have to be very careful to not. You know, find the boundaries there. So I think that probably comes with practice. I mean, I think early in my ministry career, I wasn't as good at that. And now that I've had more situations, probably on a little better at that. So practice is just like all things very important.

Interviewer 1 8:00 How is it balancing family obligations or family life and family relationships with ministry?

[Leroy] 8:14 Yeah. Yeah, that's a really tricky question because you know, ministry can have really slow times and kind of be like ohh, you know everything seems to be going fine and then there can be tragedy and they're gonna be crisis and they're going to be, you know, long nights or hospital visits or whatever. And so I mean, for instance, last Friday I had a pretty slow day and have any appointments or no major tasks. And so I just decided to spend some more time in prayer and some pastors names came to my mind. And so I just reached out and texted him, and that turned into a pretty intense hour and a half phone call with one of them. And then going to visit another who is in a health crisis and bringing him lunch. And like my day ended up filling up. So I guess with the I guess that the family is you just have to. Cherish those times that you do have a little bit of breathing room and not feel guilty about maybe not working so much

during those times, but then they also have to realize there are gonna be times that you know we're gone in the evenings for board meetings or we have these certain appointments or whatever. And so it it requires a lot of communication with the family and with. With my wife, and also requires you know that we all give a little. And so we know what ministry life is like it's not a normal nine to five job. Yeah.

Interviewer 1 9:54 Do you have more to say about that?

[Leroy] 9:56 No, I was just gonna say, you know, there's gives and there's giving. There's giving and taking through seasons as well because a lot of the times the school schedule when you have kids, you know during the school year is different than the summers. And so for me, I I have a a summer routine that's a little bit different and allows me some extended time off to be with family. And so we take longer vacations during that time and we really cherish those. So I wouldn't say it's necessarily a daily routine or a weekly, but sometimes it's a yearly rhythm that we go through.

Interviewer 1 10:30 Umm. Another thing that you brought up earlier was about the brokenness and the hurt that you're exposed to, or that you deal with when working with others. Can you say more about that as a challenge?

[Leroy] 10:57 Yeah, well, inevitably, you know. Umm. People seem to care a lot more about God and their church when they go through crisis, and that's just human nature. When you're faced with death & Major disappointments, you start to question God, and so you know, I remember a family that I was ministering too that weren't even in the church, and the mom passed away. And I spent a lot of time with that family and was in the hospital and in their house when she passed and. Those are just heavy, heavy things and then, you know, you don't hear from that family maybe for a year and then all of a sudden tragedy strikes again and a stepdaughter passes in a in a freak accident. And you know you're doing their funeral for them and and then all of a sudden, somebody calls and does a wants to you to do a wedding. And so it is unique because you experience the highest of highs and the lowest of lows with people. It's

a real honor to be there for someone's wedding and it's a huge honor to be there when you're celebrating their death, you know? So I think people have always said about me that I'm very even even keeled, that bring calmness to a room, calmness to a situation, calmness to a job, a space. And so I think that's helpful in this role, because if you're a highly charged emotional person, that can be beneficial in a lot of situations, but it also can, uh be difficult make make your life more difficult as a minister so.

Interviewer 2 12:56 You've talked a few different times about being able to move from one thing to the next easily and you use the word compartmentalize. I wonder if you could talk a little bit about that and some of the challenges with that?

[Leroy] 13:05 Mm-hmm. Yeah, sure. I mean, I think, UM. It's it's a tough tension to to manage, right? I mean, you're you're managing attention of wanting to be a great. Shepherd and love people well, but also find a boundary for your own health. And so as you give yourself away and sacrifice and serve others, there's also a time where you have to be selfish and you have to take care of yourself and Sabbath and rest. And I mean several days I will just take a nap because I need to. Physically rest, and I think it's more about emotional rest & and mental rest as well. So part of the compartmentalizing is just realizing what space you're in, and then how much recovery time you need for those spaces. Preaching a sermon isn't just like a one hour endeavor. It's, you know, a lot of preparation and then the emotion of the moment. And then there's usually a a huge like I need some rest now you know? And and so we take a nap on Sunday afternoons. Often I just cause, so that's part of the compartmentalizing I guess, is realizing the tension that you're always managing there.

Interviewer 1 14:42 Have there been times when you have not done that or or you learned that when maybe when it wasn't working or didn't do go well?

[Leroy] 14:58 Yes. I mean, I think all pastors, if they're wise, learn from their mistakes and it's so easy to want to give, give, give and go, go, go and do, do, do that. You get you can get to a point of burnout if you're not finding balance. So personally for me, in our church right now, we're working. In fact, I just finished this work an hour ago. It's called practicing the way with

John Mark Comer and he talks all about the spiritual disciplines of you know, Sabbath solitude, rest, fasting and so you know, I'm learning the practice those and not only in my life but in my community and. They're helping me find health and balance in a lot of ways that I didn't have necessarily before and and so like I said, my summer routine has always given me kind of a mini sabbatical every year, which is also helped that. But I can see a pastor, and I can tell you stories about many pastors. You don't do that. And who won't practice a weekly Sabbath or some kind of sabbatical or find rest? Thankfully, I have been able to do that fairly well until feel like a balanced individual. Did that answer your question?

Interviewer 1 16:37 Well, it sounds as if you haven't had experiences where you didn't do that well or went too far before taking care of you or your family's needs.

[Leroy] 16:52 Yeah, I I personally haven't experienced like a a pastoral burnout or, you know, some crisis point in my life. But I think there's a couple reasons #1 is that I've learned to have healthy rhythms and routines in my life, but also I have. I've changed jobs probably more frequently than some, and so I have kind of a tendency to change jobs every four or five years. And what that does is it kind of provides a new spark and a new challenge and a new adventure. And so I haven't gotten to the drudgery of, you know, being someplace for 20 years and just, you know, feeling like it's never going to end or or just pushing so hard in the course of a a week or a month or a year that I've got to print out point. So I think that's maybe been some helpful things for me as a minister.

Interviewer 1 17:58 Umm alright. A different direction then . We are curious about your spiritual relationship, your relationship with Jesus. And what that's like for you personally and what that's like for you in your ministry?

[Leroy] 18:27 Yeah, that's a great question. I don't think a person can be a a good, healthy, helpful minister if they are not, uh, solid in their relationship with Jesus. And that for me looks like I have a daily Bible reading time. I spend time daily journaling. I spend time every day in prayer. I do my best to be in community with with people around me and relationships that you know, foster my relationship with Jesus. I I spent a lot of time serving others and so practicing

these rhythms of of life have have. Helped me help others. I mean, you can't serve someone else or help someone else if you're not healthy yourself. And so, you know, like I said last Friday, there was kind of like, oh, I don't have a lot of things to do. Well, I'm gonna spend time in prayer and rest and reading. And these are kind of hobbies for me now, but I know that when that crisis comes that that for the most part, I've put enough in in my relationship with Jesus that I'm able to pour some out. So yeah, I don't know. I mean, it's just like being a Christian. I don't know how a member of the clergy could possibly, uh be successful at their job without a deep, rich dynamic relationship with Jesus.

Interviewer 1 20:04 And right now...to clarify your role... is that you're not serving a congregation as a pastor right now, is that right?

[Leroy] 20:15 Well, kind of. I do have a congregation that I'm helping with. It's a church plant and we're a shared leadership system, so I am not the sole pastor.

Interviewer 1 20:22 Ah, OK.

[Leroy] 20:27 We have three or four people that are sharing the load and I'm trying to continually give away leadership to others, so I do have a congregation that I'm involved in with a small group, and I even preached 2 days ago. But then I'm not having to preach again for another couple months. Uh, right now I'm. I would say I'm more of a pastor of pastors, so in our network of pastors, I help oversee about well, 50, something churches and more than 100 pastors. And so I'm I'm trying to help Pastor Pat pastors to help them be. Prepared and equipped and healthy. And what they're doing?

Interviewer 1 21:15 Yes. So was this different when you were pastoring as your primary role? When you were the pastor of a congregation. How was it different for you then?

[Leroy] 21:34 Yeah, good question. I think the difference is when you're a sole pastor over a congregation, you you have to think of everything. And so you're constantly thinking about, you know, kids ministry and Youth Ministry & Men's Ministry. And Women's Ministry and you know, go down the list and you're constantly trying to juggle all these things &. Ohh yeah, I have to be

ready to preach on Sunday. And who's going to lead worship then? You know who's going to take care of this situation or that situation? So it's more of a. For me it was a lot more difficult because I didn't feel like I had a team of people. I was like a sole proprietor and a business or CEO, and so that was more, more stressful. I think there are. There's more dynamics there E Now I'm balancing a lot of different roles, not only my role in this network, but also with the church and and then, you know, church plants and church renewal things and just multiple projects with our university and. Yeah. So it's just, I guess it's just different, maybe I think I have a wider swath of people that I'm working with rather than like a congregation of 100 or 200 or whatever.

Interviewer 1 23:11 Interviewer 2 do you have a questions?

Interviewer 2 23:15 Yeah, There's differences between being the solo pastor and your current role. I'm curious if that led to any of your ability to manage things differently and when you think about, you know, the emotional and spiritual challenges?

[Leroy] 23:42 Yeah. Yeah, that's a really great question. When I was a solo pastor, I kind of felt the weight of the church on my shoulder, so I felt like the results were based on me. The outcomes were based on me. Any movement that happened was based on my efforts Achievements and that was heavier because I felt like, you know, if things weren't going well or relationship bad or a Sunday was low or whatever that I took it more personally. So now I don't personally affect a congregations. Results as much you know I'm a second or third tertiary perspective there and so it's more of a coaching role, which, yeah, I think there's a different stress level there in different level of responsibility. That's a little bit lighter load. So yeah, I think that's probably a good interest. Question and something for me to think about.

Interviewer 1 24:57 Something that we've heard and want to explore further is the expectation that pastors are available for phone calls 24/7... that you need to answer that call and respond to the need. Is that something you experienced?

[Leroy] 25:23 I don't. I guess I've kind of drawn the boundary there, so I put my phone to bed at around 9:45 and it doesn't wake up till around 6:30 and it's on sleep mode. So I suppose if

someone had a tragedy in the middle of the night, I won't hear about it until I get up in the morning. I don't know if that's the right way to do ministry. Or not, but I that's what I've chosen to do. And so I don't, I don't. I do have a boundary there and there are times that I won't answer a phone call, you know, during the dinner time or a specific times of the day. I don't. I don't allow someone else's tragedy to be mine necessarily, and I try to find a healthy balance there, but I am very respectful and I do return all of my calls. All of my texts, I have two emails in my inbox and very efficient with. Communicating and responding with people. I don't know if I'm ideal for your study. If I'm too like healthy or balanced here, I'm sorry. OK.

Interviewer 1 26:42 It seems that the idea of the boundaries and the characteristics you have that really lead to not personalizing things. You've said some things about not personalizing things, drawing boundaries, and balance to spend time in the with Jesus. It seems this combination of things contribute to your health as a pastor.

[Leroy] 27:18 Yeah. Yeah. And I will say, I mean, I haven't always been that way. I mean, when I was church planting and a solo pastor. You know, there were times where it was very personal and I had a lot of frustration and anger and some of the most difficult decisions I've had to make as a pastor have been asking a family to leave our church because they weren't held. They weren't healthy or helpful, having to discipline one of our pastors and to the point of removing their credentials. I mean, those are just really heavy things and. You know, being criticized about certain things. And so I think that those are things you learn as you experience them and then you get help from other people. Fortunately, my wife is a counselor and she's she's good at helping with that. And you know, but I think pastors need other pastors and counselors. And so I think that this has been a process over time. For me.

Interviewer 2 28:41 I am curious, other than it's been a part of your own development, you said pastors need other pastors and they need counselors. And your wife as a counselor, but not your counselor? Officially, but is that? Has that been part of your process? I mean, as far as you know how that's developed for you, how those boundaries, how you came to those spaces of knowing what you needed?

[Leroy] 29:06 Yeah, I think it's all of those things. It's I spend, you know, time journaling. I have journals but till when I was in college just kind of umm processing life and you know, processing

with others in my spouse and I think God has given me the gift of encouraging. Now, other pastors and encouraging people in ministry and young adults, I mean, I just spoke with the young adult this morning on the phone and she was, you know. She's just so fast. And so you know, what's the future holding all those things? And I just, you know, just had to calmly say, like, we can't predict the future. Stop trying to predict the future. Stop trying to do these things. I've had six jobs in my life. It's OK that you're in this job now, and so it's a process. Yes, in my own life, but also now trying to give it back to other people in the journey. And it's. Yeah, it's through time with Jesus. Through journaling, through talking with others, through reading books, you know, piece of scaro whatever, healthy, emotional, spiritually is a great resource. I mean, there's just a lot of these things. And then also learning to practice it in small group settings. So.

Interviewer 1 30:38 An observation is that your your skills, your ability, and ways in which you've been able to navigate ministry. In some way, positions you as an ideal person to be pastoring to pastors because you're you're walking the walk and talking the talk that you're helping them with.

[Leroy] 31:05 Yeah.

Interviewer 1 31:08 You are modeling.

[Leroy] 31:11 Yeah, I hope so. I mean I I think so. And I mean, I spoke with the pastor last week and he was, you know, talking about resigning and the things going on his life. And I said, well, if you need to do that to be healthy, you you need to do that because the church isn't dependent on you. And I think there's a perspective that all pastors need to have is that, you know, your Sunday sermon, however bad it flops. The spirit still can work in someones life and they can hear things that you never said. The church can survive without you. You're not. You know, that's a very unhealthy place to be in thinking that you have to carry everything in the church. And so I think for me there was some perspective shifts along the way. I don't remember one moment, but multiple moments are going OK. I didn't feel good about Sunday. I don't need to drive off a Cliff right now. You know, Monday's still gonna happen and God's still working and realizing that it's not me who saves someone or something. Me, who transforms lives. It's only

by the power of Jesus, and then so for hell they pastor. You have to surrender those things because for the most part, we're control freaks in in life. You guys probably don't experience anyone like that, but I do.

Interviewer 1 32:53 Is there anything that you would like to say, not just in response to a question, but maybe when you saw the call and the research question and what we're exploring and what we're doing here, are there some things that you think would be helpful to for you to share with us or that you'd like to talk about?

[Leroy] 33:19 Ohm, I mean, for me it was really intrigued by your study because. I want my. Life's goal, I guess for my my hope is that we have very healthy uh pastors and healthy families and healthy, emotionally, spiritually. Uh, a big issue with Pastors's physical health. Umm. And so, you know, I was really interested in kind of what are some of the challenges that pastors are having & can you help them find balance and wholeness and health and that we can have people flourishing because, you know, quite frankly, at least in our group of pastors, we have less and less pastors. We have a leadership avoid right now. We're not getting a lot of new resumes. We're not getting a lot of new graduates and I think it's because they see. Not only how hard ministry. Is, but you know they don't make as much money and they have so many challenges. They're like, why would I put myself through that? So if we can, if if your study or other things can help turn turn the tide of of what ministry. Is and how? How important it is, but also what a beautiful life and a blessed life it is. I'd love to. I'd love to see our church thrive. I personally, I love the church. I love the church and in order for our churches to be healthy, we need all parts of the body of the church. Working properly, you know, so part of the body is that the Minister who helps in so many different ways and when when they're not uh, healthy and we see evidence of decline in, in the vocation, we need to find some solutions. So thank you for the work you're doing. I'll be interested in the results. Is it? And I did have a question. Is this a qualitative study that you're doing... like not 1050 people or whatever?

Interviewer 1 35:49 Yes.

Interviewer 2 35:50 Yes.

[Leroy] 35:52 OK.

Interviewer 1 35:53 Our study is across denominations and across the nation. We're exploring emotional and spiritual challenges within Christian ministry in order to identify themes.

[Leroy] 36:17 Yeah.

Interviewer 1 36:17 And so we're going to be collecting data in the first round of interviews, and then we'll be transcribing and coding. And then asking for follow up interviews, because if we see something that another person is talking about and we want to maybe circle back to see is this something that each person has experienced, then we'd want to have some follow up questions to that.

[Leroy] 36:48 Yeah, because they're seeing a pattern, yeah.

Interviewer 1 36:50 Mm-hmm. And then after the analysis and we have the findings, then we're going to provide each of the participants with the findings and then we will ask you if this resonates with your experiences. Is there anything missing? And are there parts that do or don't fit?

[Leroy] 37:15 Yeah. Yeah. So I had one more thing. Umm. Something that I think is really helped my situation is that my family has had a my family has been very healthy so have a great network of family on both sides that are healthy. None of my wife or my kids have had major crises. I mean, so there's kind of this component of ohm and this is just a blessing, nothing that we've done, but we haven't had any major health crisis or mental health crisis or anything like that. And so I just think that helps in a ministry. Situation when I do see pastors that their families in upheaval because of this situation or that situation, it's gotta be 10 times the extra weight for them to then also carry the weight of a congregation alongside of them. So I've been very blessed in that way. Uh to have to have a strong, supportive family. Parents, grandparents, relatives. Immediate family.

Interviewer 2 38:44 Yeah. Thank you.

[Leroy] 38:45 I thank you. OK. Yeah, I'm. I mean, when I see other pastors like now where I'm pastoring pastors and I suppose this is the same in a in a solo pastor of a congregation. But when I see pastors or congregation members that have deep. Crisis moments. Uh, that does affect everything. I mean, it just affects everything. And so I think for me, one advantage is just that we haven't had those yet and and hopefully never will.

Interviewer 1 39:35 Do you have any other questions?

[Leroy] 39:41 No, I don't. I hope the this is helpful. If it's not, you can just strike me out and find somebody else. But I just. I'm interested in your study and if anything in my experience is helpful then that's great.

Interviewer 1 39:52 Yeah.

[Leroy] 39:56 And if it's not, I won't take any offense to it. That's another great book.

Interviewer 2 40:02 Yeah.

[Leroy] 40:03 Is being. Ohhh, what's the name of it?

Interviewer 1 40:07 Is it an Unoffendable?

[Leroy] 40:07 Yeah, as a pastor, you just gotta learn to be unoffendable.

Interviewer 1 40:14 Umm.

[Leroy] 40:15 And that's not always easy, but yeah, if there's any other way I can help, let me know, I'll look forward to the next time we have a chance to chat.

Interviewer 1 40:17 Yeah. OK. Well, thank you very much for your time.

Interviewer 2 40:25 Thank you.

Interviewer 1 40:27 I'm going to stop the recording now.

<Interviewer 1 stopped transcription>

Categories

Pastors hold weight

Pastors need healthy minds

Pastors need rhythm in boundaries

Pastors cannot react to crisis

Pastors put themselves last

Categories (TC)

Pastors carry a heavy emotional weight and spiritual responsibility

Pastors need emotional, mental, and spiritual wellness

Pastors need to develop clear professional boundaries and work balance

Pastors need to resist the urge to be reactive and respond with thoughtfulness and intentionality

Pastors must prioritize self-care and family well-being